



The GigaByte Radeon 9600 PRO performed well in the mid-range segment

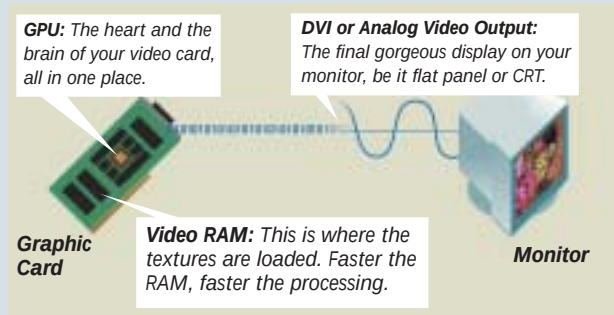
9600 will make it gain favour with consumers who want a good gaming experience at a lower price.

Of the nine graphics cards tested in this category, three were based on the ATi 9600 chipset. Hercules provided a 9600 PRO and a regular 9600 with 256 MB video RAM, while GigaByte sent a 9600 PRO card. 3DMark 2003

showed some marked differences in the scores amongst the cards. At lower resolutions in the game tests, all the cards all gave almost equivalent results. It was only on the higher resolutions that the differences showed. The two PRO cards from Hercules and GigaByte were tied neck to neck, but eventually the Gigabyte card won the race by a few points. Surprisingly, the Gigabyte 9600 PRO (128 MB) is priced lower than the Hercules 3D Prophet, even though the Hercules card afforded lower performance.

3D Graphics Card Demystified

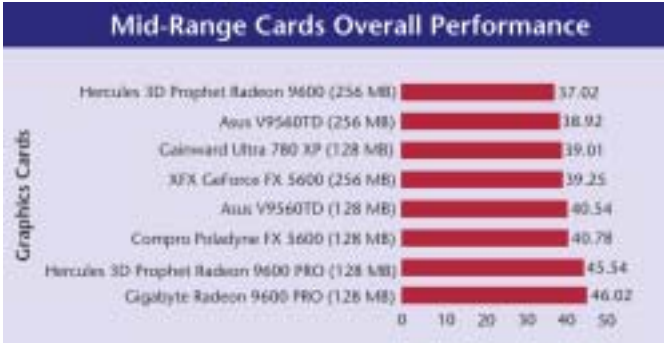
While the basic components of a graphics card have remained more or less the same in the past few years, the complexity of each component has increased exponentially. A graphics card consists of the following components:



Graphics Processor (GPU): This is the processor on your graphics card that gives it all the number crunching abilities needed to render complex graphics at high speeds.

Video memory: Memory is another important component on today's graphics cards. Apart from storing commonly require fonts, icons, bitmap images, etc., in memory, the graphics cards also have to create and store all those frames before sending them to the screen.

RAMDAC (Random Access Memory Digital-to-Analog Converter): The RAMDAC is responsible for putting all the stuff in the video memory onto the monitor. It does this by converting each digital value stored in the memory to a corresponding analog signal. This can be understood by the monitor using a Digital-to-Analog (DAC) circuit. In fact, it has three separate DACs to convert each RGB component to the full spectrum of colours that the monitor supports. The speed of the RAMDAC is very crucial and has a huge impact on the ability of the graphics card to support different resolutions at different colour depths and refresh rates.



There was a huge performance difference between the 9600 and the 9600 PRO cards, and the price difference of just about Rs 1,000 to Rs 2,000 makes the 9600 a no-go.

The other four cards in this category were based on the nVidia 5600 chipset—the Compro Paladyn FX 5600 (128 MB), Pine XFX 5600, Asus V9560TD and the Asus V9560TD (256 MB). There was also a 5600 Ultra card, the Gainward Ultra 780 XP. The Gainward 5600 Ultra did not give better performance than the 5600 cards, but it has a lower price tag, which gave it the best value award in this category. The performance of all the four 5600 cards was lower than the two 9600 PRO cards, but what was really surprising was the pricing. The lowest performer in the 5600 cards, the Asus V9560TD (256 MB), costs Rs 2,750 more than the best-performing card in the entire category, the Gigabyte Radeon 9600 PRO.

ATI's cards clearly had the upper hand in this category.

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